

BCCF E-MAIL BULLETIN #490

Your editor welcomes any and all submissions – news of upcoming events, tournament reports, and anything else that might be of interest to BC players. Thanks to all who contributed to this issue. To subscribe, send me an e-mail (swright2@telus.net); if you no longer wish to receive this Bulletin, just let me know.

Stephen Wright



BC Chess Federation

HERE AND THERE

Okanagan Valley Rapid 8 (September 19)



(photo by [Chess Maps](#))

In September 2024 the Fraser Valley Chess Academy hosted Okanagan Valley Rapid 1, helping revive competitive chess in the area. Here we are two years later and the series continues with edition eight, held like the others at the Okanagan Regional Library in West Kelowna. Zachary Burrows held a substantial rating advantage over the other twenty-one players in the [Open Section](#) which he put to good use in claiming first prize with 5.5/6, giving up a draw to third-place finisher Wade Courson. The big surprise was Hao Wang, playing in only his third rated event with a provisional rating of 1295, who finished clear second with 5.0 points, this after receiving a full-point bye in the first round due to his low rating. The [U1400 Section](#) was won by top-ranked Alexander Campbell, also with 5.5/6, while half of the remaining six players tied for second two points back: Hargun Khakh, Vanya Sweeney, and Sarah Keenan. Zachary Burrows also won the adjunct [Blitz](#) event with a perfect 6.0/6, Wade Courson was second this time, and Clayton Kichuk, Cole Toponce, Alp Topcu, and Julian Hook tied for third.

Simultaneous Display with FM Lucas Yao (September 14)

There was a time when simultaneous exhibitions were part and parcel of any professional chess player's life; in previous decades and centuries tournaments were nowhere near as plentiful as

they are now, and chess masters would engage in long tours giving simultaneous displays to pay the bills. In BC those that come immediately to mind are Frank Marshall ([1913](#)), Max Euwe ([1949](#)), Samuel Reshevsky ([1954 and 1956](#)), and [Paul Keres](#) and [Boris Spassky](#) (1967). Although rarer now, simultaneous exhibitions still serve as a great way to promote chess and create a public spectacle as one takes on many.



(photo by [Chess Maps](#); more [photos](#))

At the beginning of August GM Samy Shoker gave such a display in Nanaimo, and now FM Lucas Yao has demonstrated his skills in an exhibition at the North Atrium of the newly renovated Oakridge Park in Vancouver. A means of celebrating and promoting a new partnership between [Vancity Chess](#) and Oakridge Park, twelve-year-old Lucas, who received his FM title based on his result in the Canadian Closed last April, took on a total of twenty-two players with a final score of seventeen wins, two draws and three losses or just under 82% - congratulations! The weekly casual chess meetup is currently taking place at [Oakridge Park](#) on Saturdays from 11am to 1pm.

RCC Elite Championship (September 13)

The September Richmond Chess Champions Elite Championship (four rounds at 50 + 10) had a smaller turnout than usual, with only a dozen players in a single [U1500 Section](#). A quarter of them tied for first with 3.0 points each: Oliver Slater-Kinghorn, Yude Lin, and Yuhong Chen.

Victoria Autumn Rapid (September 13) by Paul Leblanc

An excellent turn-out of forty-eight players met at the Esquimalt Recreation Centre on Sunday, September 13 for a CFC-rated, six-round Rapid tournament. The event attracted eight new CFC members, a promising sign for the future of chess in Victoria. It was also a family-oriented event with thirteen players receiving family-friendly pairings where family members are not paired against each other unless there is no other option. There was also good representation from

Comox, Campbell River, Nanaimo and Maple Bay. This tournament featured a change to our traditional G/25 min + 5 sec time control. The “new” time control was G/15 min +10 sec, aligning with the most popular Rapid time control in online chess and in the rest of BC. Organizer was Paul Leblanc and TD was Michael Beaulieu.



NM Roger Patterson (left). Final round win against Jacob Tarasoff clinches 1st place.

Roger cruised to victory with 5.5/6, surrendering only one draw to James Nah of Comox. Second place was a three-way tie between three Victoria players, Denis Shumeyko, Emilian Holmgren, and Hailay Teklemariam, all at 5.0/6. The top U1600 prize was split between Darrend Brown of Victoria, Seshadri Sai Sowmiya Narayanan, and Coen Holmgren, both of North Saanich, all at 4.0/6. Top U1400 was Mya Bruckner, also at 4.0/6. Top unrated was Ryan Licayan of Victoria at 4.0/6. [Standings](#)



Mya Bruckner, winner of the U1400 prize (right), Hailay Teklemariam (left). Raymond Manguerra (left) vs Emilian Holmgren (right) at the next board.

King County Open (September 12-13)



As we saw last issue, whatever political differences there might be between Canada and the United States, there are still a fair number of BC players travelling to Washington State to play chess. The latest example is the [King County Open](#), held at the Embassy Suites Hotel in Bellevue on the weekend after Labour Day and consisting of a five-round Swiss with a time control of 75 + 30. Those Canadians making the trip included Evelyn Lou, Sining Lou, NCM Samuel Lu, CM Barath Subramanian Suresh, Yaswitha Suresh, Jordan Szeto, Martina Szeto, WCM Joanne Wangluo, NCM Aiden Yin, and CM Andrew Yin. A total of one hundred and thirty players participated in the various sections, with Vidip Kumar Kona being the overall winner after defeating GM Vladimir Belous in round three; Andrew Yin was amongst those who tied for fifth with 3.0 points, and Yaswitha Suresh tied for second and was top female in the U1100 Section. Joanne Wangluo won a biggest upset prize in the first round while Samuel Lu and Yaswitha also won prizes in the Blitz.

Seattle Chess Club Masters (September 5-7)

The previous weekend Seattle Chess Club hosted an event for those rated over 2000; among the thirty-seven players were FM John Doknjas, CM Neil Doknjas, CM Zachary Liu, CM Barath Subramanian Suresh, and NM Tristan Taylor from this province. IM Alexander Katz topped the [crosstable](#) with a final score of 5.0/6; Neil Doknjas and Zachary Liu tied for seventh with eight other players on 3.5 points.

Langley Short August Quads (August 10, 17, 24)

Three double round robins at a time control of 25 + 10 with games on three consecutive Mondays. Vlad Gaciu has only recently returned to chess (his last event was the 2009 BC Open) but he won [Quad 1](#) with a perfect score (being highest rated helps), Manuel Fernando was second and Mark Gulbinowicz third. [Quad 2](#) was dominated by Muhammad Qaqib with 5.0/6 followed by Noel Roy and Maksim Lokiae and Kyler Bruntlett third. And Peter Gibson and Kapil Garg tied for first in [Quad 3](#), Isaac Bellosillo placed third.

BC-WA CHALLENGE MATCH (September 5-7)



As noted last issue, since 2019 the annual [BC-WA match](#) has been held as a Swiss event, with equal numbers of each side competing and the proviso that members of the same team would not be paired against each other. This year the event was hosted by the Richmond Chess Champions and featured eleven players on each side. On paper Washington held a small lead by average rating (1735 to 1705) yet the individual round [scores](#) were not close. In the first round BC won by 8.5-2.5 but thereafter it was all Washington: 4.0-7.5, 3.0-8.0, 3.5-7.5, and 3.5-7.5 respectively for a grand total of BC 22.5 points to Washington's 33.0. (One BC player took a half-point bye and his Washington opponent received a full point, hence the half-point discrepancy in the totals.) Prizes were awarded to the top three scorers on each team. For Washington these were Sloan Setiadikurnia (4.5), Josh Sinanan (3.5), and third shared by Sridhar Seshadri, Atharv Rastogi, Skandha Raj, Warren Chung, Lewis Ma, and Siva Sankrithi (3.0 points each). All the BC top scorers finished with 3.5 points: Karson Lu, Ella Wu, and Jordan Szeto. With this victory Washington has won two in a row and goes some way to answering BC's previous [string](#) (it's much easier to play at home).

LANGLEY OPEN (September 5-7)

2026 marks the twentieth year since the former Labour Day Open in Victoria was transferred to the Mainland and became the Langley Open (my, how time flies!). Perhaps appropriately in light of this anniversary, after two years away in other locations the tournament this year returned to its traditional home, the Brookwood Senior Centre in south Langley. Co-organized by the Langley Chess Club and Fraser Valley Chess Academy, the event attracted ninety-nine players in the by now familiar three sections. (Langley always used to be a single-section open, but larger turnouts have necessitated smaller divisions.) The thirty-six player [Open](#) included ten players rated over 2000 but the tournament soon developed into a race between NM Yidong Chen and T G M Peiris, the only two people with a perfect score after three rounds. They were paired together in round four, Chen won, after which Chen drew his remaining games while Peiris had to win both of his (he did) in order to tie for first with Chen, they both finished with 5.0 points. Chen received the coveted last qualification spot for the BC Closed on tiebreak. Top ranked FM Jingyun (Ryan) Yang gave up one too many draws and tied for third place with Severyn Smykalo on 4.5 points.



(photo by [Chess Maps](#))

The [U1600 Section](#) saw the only perfect score of the event as Manuel Fernando produced a picket fence in claiming first place. Roy Lau, Matvey (Matt) Loktionov, and Yongha Yang tied for second a point and a half behind. And Sean Zhang and Jamie Francheska Nones both scored 5.0 points in the [U1100 Section](#) to share first and second places, while third was split between Jake Frew and Ruiyang Gu with 4.5 points.

VANCOUVER CHESS FESTIVAL #15 (September 19-20)

Another school year begins, which brings the return of Vancouver Chess School's Chess Festivals to the Ponderosa Ballroom at UBC. This fifteenth edition continued with the same format as last season with three separate tournaments: a five-round classical over two days, a seven-round blitz on the Saturday evening, and a Regional qualifier for the BC Chess Challenge on the Sunday. The Classical had the same five sections as previously, with 400-point sections below the Open starting at U2100. Highest rated in the twenty-five player [Open Section](#) was FM Jingyun (Ryan) Yang and he duly won the first prize with 4.5/5, his draw being in the last round with NM Yidong Chen who tied for second with NCM Aiden Yin. The remaining place prizes were split between Viktor Musakhanyan, Minjun Koo, and CM Barath Subramanian Suresh, while Hasmik Margaryan was the Best Female. Veteran NM Mayo Fuentebella was the clear winner of the [U2100 Section](#), also with 4.5 points, just ahead of newcomer Kirill Stancev and James Fu who tied for second. Gyuwon Lee, Jaydon Yuan, Xavier Zhang, and Manuel Fernando all finished on 3.5, and the Top Female was Ella Wu.

The [U1700 Section](#) was won by Jason Ji with a perfect score, a point ahead of Kallum Moy, Fabio Prado, and Chelsea Tang, while the Best Female prize went to Echo Fang. There was a logjam at the top of the [U1300 Section](#) as Tsz Chung (James) Law, Charlie Qiao, Kian Gupta, and Jamie Francheska Nones all finished on 4.0/5; Chenhan Ma was the Best Female. And in the [U900 Section](#) Sam Zhao was perfect in taking first, Oleksandr Gordienko was second on tiebreak over Youyi (Lewis) Liu. A total of one hundred and twenty-one players participated in the Classical Sections.

The Blitz tournament, a seven-round Swiss at 3 + 2, took place on the Saturday evening with a total of forty-three participants. NM Ryan Leong was the class of the field in the [Open Section](#),

scoring six wins in a row before a draw in the last round to claim the first prize, a full point and a half in front of FM Jingyun (Ryan) Yang, Dongkai (Harry) Wang, and Minjun Koo. Matthew Kofmansky was perfect in winning the [U1400 Section](#), Sam Zhao was second, and Eduardo Maldonado Diaz, Nathan Mah, and William Weng shared the third prize.

Results of the Regional can be found [here](#).

THE DANGERS OF A DEFENSIVE MINDSET, AND BACKWARD MOVES by George Kosinski

There are several reasons one could wind up playing defensively for some time. One is making a bad mistake that leaves you feeling like you're about to fall off the edge of a cliff for the rest of the game (assuming the position isn't immediately resignable). Another is being subjected to a lengthy attack when there's no counterplay and your only hope is surviving the attack. If you do so successfully, you might even have the better position after the smoke clears, especially if your opponent sacrificed material for his/her attack. Oddly enough, a benefit of being under attack (I know – a strange turn of phrase) is that survival often involves a series of only moves, a very different scenario from having to choose among equally plausible continuations. Perhaps the most common reason for plugging into a defensive mindset is being under sustained positional pressure for some time, a reliable winning strategy responsible for the popularity of positional pawn and exchange sacrifices. I'm still smarting from a missed opportunity many years ago, but I want to begin with a game from a very recent tournament. In the 2026 BC Day Summer Open, my first game was against the highest rated player in the tournament. I misplayed the opening, resulting in having to retreat an active piece to its original square, and it wasn't the kind of retreat that has any upside. By my 20th move, I was under sustained positional pressure due to White's pressure down the long white diagonal combined with her control of the semi-open c-file, not to mention the c5-square, in concert with her massive space advantage. However, her very next move allowed me to neutralize the pressure on the long diagonal by forcing a queen trade, albeit at the cost of submitting to an isolated e-pawn. And that wasn't her only mistake. Thirteen moves later, she erred in not playing a move to secure her knight outpost on c5. But instead of breathing a sigh of relief at her missed opportunity and looking for a way to exploit that mistake, I had already abandoned hope of generating any counterplay, instead remaining in a mindset of



continuing to look for moves that could justify not resigning immediately, as opposed to trying to find good moves. This was the position after Black's 32nd move. Here White should have played 33.a5, securing her knight outpost with a total clamp on the queenside, and leaving my position close to resignable with no realistic counterplay on the kingside, while the knight's control of e6 also plays a significant role. I could survive into a pawn down double-rook endgame, but White's rooks would be so dominant that the only hope of a draw would be an extremely unlikely blunder by White, so my belief that my position would collapse after the loss of my e-pawn was not far from the truth. Anyway, White missed this opportunity [and played Rcd2], leading to the next position.



Here I spent around five minutes considering 33...Nc4 but eventually concluded that there's no point, as 34.Rc2 would force my knight to retreat (34.Rd7+ isn't as good as it looks, though White does retain a slight advantage after 34...Be7), after which White would be free to make a better move. Sadly, it didn't occur to me that after 34.Rc2, I would not be obliged to return the knight to d6. In fact, it could go to the far better square e5, when Black has good chances to hold despite the (inevitable) loss of his e-pawn. Even better, however, is 34...Nb6!, when the attack on the d5-rook would give Black time for 35...a5, after which the tables are turned and it is Black who has winning chances. Despite 34...Nb6 being the best move (after 34.Rc2), this position highlights a common blind spot in calculations –

a piece being blocked for so many moves that you don't notice when it's no longer blocked. My bishop was blocked for such an extensive period that in my calculations I didn't even notice that ...Bxc5 would be a legal move after the knight's departure from d6, another side effect of mental energy going into emotional reactions to your position instead of being fully focused on evaluation and calculation. I'm curious as to whether I would have noticed ...Bxc5 as a possible move even if I had played 33...Nc4(!)

Of course, 34.Rc2 isn't forced, but other moves still allow Black to fully equalize with 34...a5 if he has nothing better. Unfortunately, none of these considerations crossed my mind, despite the ease of calculation. Why? Primarily because I was so plugged into the idea I was bound to lose that, subconsciously, I wasn't looking for good moves; I was only looking for moves that could justify not resigning immediately. But an added factor is the problem of overlooking backward moves. Not considering 34...Ne5 (after 34.Rc2 – or even some other moves) is understandable since it involves the immediate abandonment of the e-pawn. But failing to notice that 34...Nb6 would be attacking the d5-rook, allowing time to undermine the knight outpost on c5, can only be attributed to a mindset so defensive that it excludes the possibility of thinking that one might ever



get a chance for any kind of counterplay. No sooner had Fritz pointed out that 34...Nb6 is not only a good move, but would turn the evaluation in Black's favour, then I remembered a painful lesson on backward moves from the 2014 Grand Pacific Open.

Max Gedajlovic had just played 31.Rc8?!, when 31.Rc6 instead would have left him with an almost winning advantage (Note that after 31.Rc6 Nd4, White can ignore the threat to his rook. After 32.Kf2 Nxc6?!, 33.dxc6 wins pretty much on the spot). I had been on the ropes for a while and was itching to get my unemployed knight doing something – anything! I don't think I took more than a few seconds to play 31...Nd4? With a rating of 2091 (now 2332), I certainly wasn't hoping that Max would

play 32.Ra8, allowing the cheapo 32...Ne2+ followed by winning the bishop. My idea was simply that at least my knight is in enemy territory, where it might have a chance to make itself useful in some fashion – following the general rule that you want your pieces moving forward rather than backward. And here again, because the notion that I might want to move my knight backward rather than forward never crossed my mind, I overlooked the simple double attack 31...Ne7! followed by the capture of White's d-pawn, when the position has instantly transformed from a big advantage for White to a complex position with chances for both sides. But even worse, I failed to notice that White would not be able to prevent the loss of his d-pawn even without the double attack. My (subconscious?) belief that retreating the knight to e7 would be a terribly passive move overrode the reality of the position on the board. For more on this, see the *Backward Knight Moves* article in the February 2025 edition of *Chess Life* [page 12 – available [online](#)]. I've had a number of painful reminders that, as Yusupov asserted, being good at selecting candidate moves is more important than your calculating ability (a minimum level of competence being, of course, required). I've been trying to pursue a policy of looking at every legal move before considering potential candidate moves – at least when there are no immediate tactics or crushing positional moves available – but old habits are hard to break.

The following example is not notable for any particular reason other than highlighting the challenge of considering backward moves, especially when there is no immediate concrete tactical or positional reason for doing so.



This position arose in a 1951 game where Smyslov was White, and here it's White to play. It might be worth your while to think about what you would play here, despite already having a hint.

Smyslov played 22.Qe2. I don't have the expertise to suggest why he chose this move, but future technology has confirmed that this apparently passive move is the best move in the position. How many club players would give even a passing thought to the idea that this might be a viable candidate move? And speaking of **concrete** reasons for making backward moves, especially returning a piece to its original square, I suppose the most famous example is the one Larry Christiansen used to beat Karpov in twelve moves in the 1993 Wijk aan Zee tournament.

Christiansen, Larry Mark (2620) – Karpov, Anatoly (2725) [E12]

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.a3 Ba6 5.Qc2 Bb7 6.Nc3 c5 7.e4 cxd4 8.Nxd4 Nc6 9.Nxc6 Bxc6 10.Bf4 Nh5 11.Be3 Bd6 12.Qd1 1–0

Emanuel Lasker was the first prominent player to appreciate the importance of psychology in chess, and my experience has convinced me that it can play as significant a role as material, space, or time, which means that developing the habit of reflecting on your state of mind before looking for candidate moves might be as effective at improving your playing strength as any other exercise.

COMING EVENTS: see listings at [CFC](#), [BCCF](#) and [Northwest chess](#) websites

LIC Invitational 7 Richmond, October 3-4, [Details](#)

PCC Rapid Tournament New Westminster, October 4, [Details](#)

RCC Elite Championship Richmond, October 4, [Details](#)

UBC Rapid 1 Vancouver, October 4, [Details](#)

Thanksgiving Open Surrey, October 9-12, [Details](#)

BC Women's Championship Surrey, October 10-12, [Details](#)

Fraser Valley Classical 7 Langley, October 17-18, [Details](#)

Jack Taylor Memorial Victoria, October 23-25, [Details](#)

UBC Fall Open Vancouver, October 23-25, [Details](#)

RCC Elite Rapid Richmond, October 25, [Details](#)

RCC Elite Championship Richmond, November 1, [Details](#)

Langley Fall Classic Langley, starting November 2, [Details](#)

RCC Elite Rapid Richmond, November 8, [Details](#)

Scholastic Junior Rapid Championship Port Coquitlam, November 8, [Details](#)

Vancouver Chess Festival 16 Vancouver, November 14-15, [Details](#)

Greater Vancouver Chess Tournament 12 Burnaby, November 21-22, [Details](#)

BC Junior Championship Richmond, November 28-29, [Details](#)